



Pilgrim Paths

St Thomas à Becket, Huntingdon, HR5 3PY



3.1 mile circular walk

*A couple of high stiles and lots of sheep
Kington Pilgrim Paths from St Thomas à Becket*

Welcome to the Kington Benefice Pilgrims Paths Project

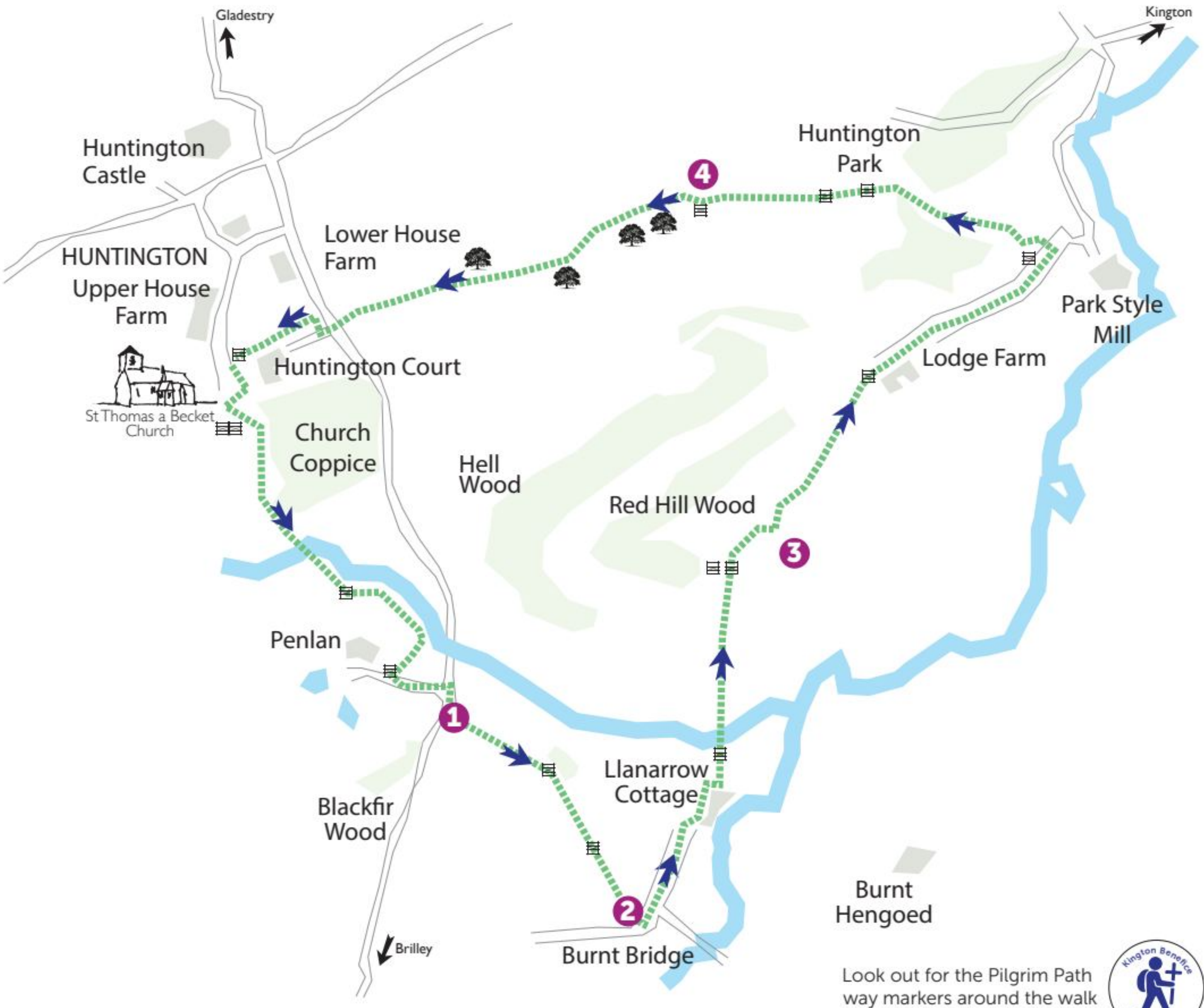
A pilgrimage is a spiritual journey to a sacred place. From earliest times, people have travelled to the 'thin places' of the world which offer opportunities for reflection and encounter. Pilgrim routes have shaped the landscape and history of this country from medieval times to the present day, as well as playing a major part in the spiritual journeys of many of its inhabitants.

The churches of the Kington Benefice offer you the hospitality of their buildings, which are open daily and the opportunity to explore the local environment along ancient ways, through outstanding landscapes.

We invite you to make this short pilgrim journey in a spirit of openness to what it might offer, delight in the countryside through which you travel and companionship with those who have travelled this way before and will do so after you.

The reflections in this leaflet are based on the Psalms, 150 ancient poems which form part of the Christian Bible. They deal with the whole range of human experience and contain much wisdom. We hope you find them a useful source of encouragement and support as you journey.

*Kington Pilgrim Paths from St Thomas à Becket Church. 3.4 miles circular walk.
A couple of high stiles, and lots of sheep.*



Look out for the Pilgrim Path way markers around the walk



At the church door

'The Lord is my shepherd' (v1)

Psalm 23 is a good psalm for a journey - the first few verses introducing the image of God as our shepherd, show us the places where we can rest and relax. But these are only temporary resting places; the psalmist, like us, is on a journey and must travel onwards.

May you know the presence of the God who draws you and guides you, accompanying you on the journey that lies ahead.

From the church porch head straight ahead, go through the kissing gate and follow the track up the hill besides Church Coppice.

At the top of the hill go through the gate and follow the natural shaped track down the hill. At the bottom of the slope go through the right hand gate and continue along the path beside the wood towards the stile at the top left hand corner of the field.

Go over the stile and follow the outer edge of the field all the way around until you come to a steep stile in the hedge onto the road. If you find this stile too difficult to get over continue up to the corner of the field and go through the gate onto the road at the entrance to the farm.

Turn left down the road to the T junction with the lane.

1 *'He restores my soul; he leads me in the paths of righteousness'. (v3)*

Here at the junction of roads and paths, we can consider which paths are the 'righteous' ones for our own lives. Who will we choose to lead us? Where and how will we seek restoration for our souls? Spending time in nature has proven benefits, not just for our bodies but for our hearts and souls as well as we celebrate God in creation.

Turn right then almost immediately on your left is a double five bar gate. Go through the gate and walk straight ahead down the field towards a patch of woodland - there is a stile over into the next field. Go straight down this large field to another stile, go over this and head to the right hand corner of the field and through a gate onto the Tarmac road.

2 *'Though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death I will fear no evil, for you are with me' (v4)*

Less than half a mile from here lies the settlement of Burnt Hengoes, so named because in these Border Lands, it was frequently attacked by opposing forces. Our Shepherd does not always keep us from danger; that is why we are given space to lament when things do not go well for us. But the valley is only filled with the shadow of death, for Christ has defeated death and we are heirs of his victory.

Turn left and walk along the road until you reach the new footpath gate just before Llanarrow Cottage. Skirt around Llanarrow and just after you reach the end of the building bear diagonally left towards the top left hand corner of the field where there is a gate. Go through the gate and over the small stream. Then head straight in front going slightly uphill towards a pair of five bar gates.

3 *You set a table before me...you anoint my head with oil, my cup overflows' (v5)*

In the spring and summer this valley glows with young growth of almost overwhelming green. This Psalm calls us through the centuries to an attitude of grateful thanks for the food we enjoy as well as an awareness of those who live in scarcity. We are called to cultivate a spirit of thankfulness and generosity as we share our plenty with others.

Go through the right hand gate and follow the green bridle path until you reach Lodge Farm.

Go through the gate onto the track/road to Lodge Farm and turn right. At the bottom of the hill at the T junction turn left and go into Park Meadow through the gate on your left. You should now be heading to the opposite corner of the field slightly uphill.

Go through this gate and take the path to the right then to the left through the woods, this brings you to a T junction in the woods, take the path to the left towards a wooden kissing gate.

Go through the wooden kissing gate into a long meadow with a stream running along the centre.

Walk along the meadow parallel with the right hand hedge and over the stile in front of you.

4 *'Goodness and mercy will follow me all the days of my life.'* (v6a)

As we near the end of our journey we can look back not just on this pilgrimage but on our lives so far. We are reminded that however far we might stray from the path, the persistent love of God will follow us and the way back will always lie open to us.

Now head up along the hedgeline up the field beside the mature oak trees, heading for the isolated oak tree up the slope. When you get to this tree you will see ahead at the top of the field a larger tree in the hedgerow. Head for this tree and go up the track on the left hand side of the hedge towards the road.

Cross over the road, go over the green cattle grid and just after Little Lodge on your right, go over the stile on the right hand side of the drive into the field then walk up the hedgeline, over another stile and you will find yourself at the corner of the churchyard.

Go through over the stile and through the trees a few metres and through the metal kissing gate back into the church yard.

Pilgrim God

Be thou a bright flame before me

Be thou a guiding star above me

Be thou a smooth path below me

Be thou a kindly shepherd behind me

Today, tonight and forever.

Amen

(St Columba 521-297)





Back at the Church door.

'I will dwell in the house of the Lord my whole life long' (v6b)

The Psalmist ends with a promise for himself and all future readers and we continue our life's journey secure in the knowledge that Christ walks beside us as our companion, sustains us as the path beneath our feet and comes to greet us as we approach our destination.

May God the father who created you,
guide your footsteps;

May God the Son who redeemed you,
share your journey;

May God the Holy Spirit who sanctifies you,
lead you on life's pilgrimage;

and the blessing of God, Father, Son and Holy Spirit
be with you wherever you may go.

Pilgrim Paths

Kington Benefice

Pilgrimage Paths across the Benefice

The circular walks include walking on local roads, bridleways and footpaths through woods and field. There are some stiles and some moderate ascents. You may encounter sheep, cattle or horses.

Countryside code : Respect, Protect, Enjoy!

Respect other people

- *Consider the local community and other people enjoying the outdoors*
- *Leave gates and property as you find them and follow paths unless wider access is available*

Protect the natural environment

- *Leave no trace of your visit and take your litter home*
- *Keep dogs under effective control*

Enjoy the outdoors

- *Plan ahead and be prepared*
- *Follow advice and local signs.*

St Thomas à Becket, Huntington, is part of the Sanctuary Network

<https://www.britishpilgrimage.org/sanctuary-network>



Kington Benefice

www.kingtonparishes.org.uk